

The discipline of attention is older than the disciplines that depend on it. The mathematician and the carpenter share a single habit: each looks at the object until the object begins to explain itself. Books, lathes, equations, paragraphs all yield to the same patient looking; the looker, in turn, comes back altered.

What an archive teaches, slowly, is that even the most particular case sits in a series. The single letter belongs to a correspondence, the correspondence to a life, the life to a neighborhood of contemporary lives whose details the writer would not have known to enumerate. Reading a single document well always involves estimating, somewhere out of the corner of the eye, the size of the surrounding series.

The trouble with originality, said the painter, is that it cannot be planned for. You can prepare the workshop, sharpen the tools, stretch the canvas, lay out the colors in the order you intend to use them, and the morning still arrives in which the work either turns up or doesn't, and there is no procedure that makes the difference. The procedure narrows the field; the field still has to be entered.

When a body of writing has accumulated long enough, the writer's habits become legible to the writer in a way they were not legible at the moment of composition. This is one of the gifts of an archive — it allows you to be your own first reader at a critical distance you could not produce on demand. What you thought was a fresh choice you find you have made eleven times before; what you thought was an inheritance you find you yourself invented and forgot.